

Fig. 6.2: Worn-out section of the Rajula Mandagiri edict

The medium that came to be used for inscribing royal epigraphs in early India depended upon the message and the audience addressed. Two demi-official epigraphs of Mauryan times, one from Mahasthangarh in Bangladesh and the other from Sohgaura in Uttar Pradesh, recorded instructions for the distribution of grain during drought and famine.[9] The commands were intended for ‘mahamatras’, a category of administrators associated specifically with urban centres, and were inscribed on plaques. More common are donative epigraphs of the type which were engraved into what was being dedicated. King Kharavela in Orissa in the first century BCE recorded the dedication of residences to Jaina monks in the Hathigumpha rocks—the caves themselves constituting the donation. He also used his dedication to indulge in much chest-thumping, graphically describing how he defeated and terrified many contemporary rulers into submission.[10] The early edicts of Ashoka were addressed to his administrators too, but were